

Crocodylomorphs

Crocodylomorphs (which means having a crocodile-like shape) were part of the archosaur, or “ruling reptile” group, along with dinosaurs and pterosaurs. Some were small, others gigantic, and they lived both on land and in the sea. Like their modern relatives—crocodiles and alligators—most were active hunters, always ready to ambush passing fish or land animals.

Sphenosuchus

SFEN-oh-soo-kuss

- **When** 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** S. Africa
- **Habitat** Land
- **Length** 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- **Diet** Small land animals

Sphenosuchus was one of the earlier crocodylomorphs. It had long and slender legs—a sign it could run fast when chasing prey or fleeing from predators. Only a skull and a few leg bones have been found. Air-filled spaces in parts of the skull resemble those found in birds, hinting at an evolutionary link between crocodylomorphs and birds.

Geosaurus

GEE-oh-SORE-us

- **When** 165–140 million years ago (Late Jurassic to Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Europe, N. America, the Caribbean
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Fish

When scientists first came across fossils of this species they thought it lived on land, and gave it the name *Geosaurus*, or “earth lizard.” They now know that this animal spent most of its life underwater. *Geosaurus* had a much longer and narrower snout than most crocodylomorphs. It may also have had a special gland in its mouth, like crocodiles and gharials, to help it remove salt from the water it drank.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long bodies
- Short, strong limbs
- Powerful jaws
- Sharp teeth

When

Crocodylomorphs first appeared 225 million years ago, in the Late Triassic and were the ancestors of modern crocodiles and alligators.

Platelike scales
made of bone